India is no exception to the larger trends that have strengthened nationalism. Ordinary people have strong feelings on national welfare and collective prospects. They respond not just to surgical strikes like Uri and Balakot or a border face-off but even to more arcane issues like membership of the Nuclear Suppliers Group or elections to international bodies. The steady growth of its economy and the emergence of an aspirational generation with greater connectivity to the world fuels this process. There are social forces at work as well, as our power structure has broadened over the years to capture greater diversity and reflect stronger roots.

In emotional terms, nationalism obviously contributes to a stronger sense of unity. In political terms, it signifies a greater determination to combat both sub-national and supra-national challenges to it. In policy terms, it focuses on how to maximize national capabilities and influence. In India's current situation, that has a particular relevance to security. Overall, a nationalistic foreign policy outlook is likely to approach the world with more confidence and greater realism. What may be different about India is that unlike in many other powers, that sense of nationalism does not translate into an 'us versus the world' mentality. For reasons that derive from our innate pluralism, there is a tradition of reconciling the nationalism with global engagement. Not driven by victimhood, it has the potential to serve as a bridge between the established and emerging orders.

Nationalism being a product of politics and identity, India has had to grapple with both when it comes to its immediate periphery. Its civilizational influence has obviously been much broader than contemporary political boundaries. But new nationalisms may not be readily amenable to building on old connections. As a result, its interface with proximate areas as well as extended neighbours was significantly diluted. The challenge, therefore, is to rebuild a fractured region while re-establishing linkages beyond. The two goals can be self-supporting if both processes go well; or much harder if either stumble.

Where South Asia is concerned, shared history and divided sociology make for natural sensitivity. A resulting wariness is sometimes visible, especially in elite attitudes. That must be addressed as India builds understanding with society as a whole. It would require providing larger reassurance, while